CHAPTER 9 · DEEP DIVE · A HOUSE DIVIDED

Black Officeholders

For the first time, Black Americans helped write the laws — in statehouses, in Congress, even in the Senate. 1868–1877.

Name: _____ **Period:** _____ **Date:** _____

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Why does it matter who gets to sit in the room where the laws are made?

From Enslaved to Lawmaker

A DEMOCRATIC REVOLUTION

Protected by the new amendments and the Black vote, Reconstruction opened the doors of government to Black men for the first time. Some 2,000 Black men held public office across the South — from local sheriffs and school board members to state legislators.

In South Carolina's legislature, Black representatives were for a time the majority. Men who had been enslaved a few years earlier were now writing laws, funding schools, and rebuilding their states.

The First Black Congressmen

CURRIER & IVES, 1872

Senator Hiram Revels (far left) and the first Black members of the U.S. House. Revels took the very Senate seat once held by Jefferson Davis, president of the Confederacy.

"The First Colored Senator and Representatives in the 41st and 42nd Congress of the United States" — lithograph, Currier & Ives, 1872, public domain (Library of Congress).

Revels, Bruce, and the Rest

TO THE CAPITOL

Sixteen Black men served in Congress during Reconstruction. Hiram Revels of Mississippi became the first Black U.S. Senator in 1870. Blanche K. Bruce, also of Mississippi, became the first to serve a full Senate term.

They and their colleagues pushed for public schools, civil rights, and fairer laws — governing for all citizens, not just Black ones.

The five military districts, 1867 — map, © ShadowDog Digital Studios (SDS Digital Collection).

A Promise Glimpsed — Then Buried

WHY IT MATTERS

This was a genuine, if brief, flowering of biracial democracy — something the nation had never seen. It proved that Black Americans could and would govern wisely, given the chance.

That is exactly why its enemies worked so hard to erase it. After Reconstruction, the “Lost Cause” myth falsely painted these governments as corrupt and incompetent, to justify stripping Black Americans of power. Recovering the true story is an act of historical significance — deciding what deserves to be remembered.

Measure the Significance

YOUR TURN

You'll weigh what Black officeholding meant and practice historical significance — judging why it mattered then, and why remembering it matters now.